

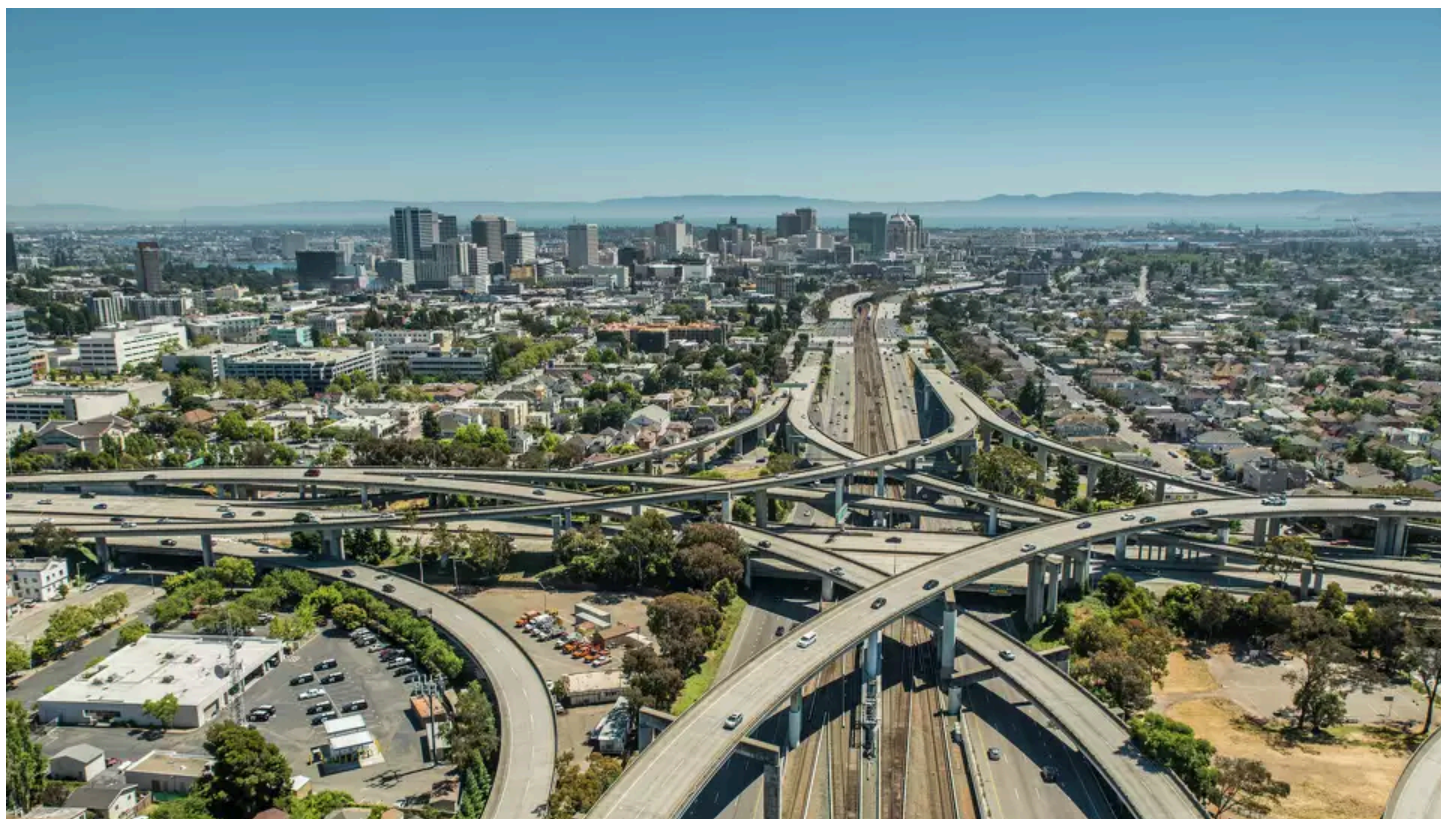


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Oakland to install network of nearly 500 surveillance cameras

By **Madilynne Medina**, News Reporter

Updated April 2, 2024 5:56 p.m.





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Oakland to install network of nearly 500 surveillance cameras

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LATEST April 2, 5:55 p.m. The California Highway Patrol provided additional details to SFGATE about the 480 surveillance cameras set to be installed on Oakland streets and six East Bay freeways, as Gov. Gavin Newsom's office announced Friday.

Jaime Coffee, a CHP spokesperson, told SFGATE that Interstate 580 will have 78 cameras. Interstate 80 will have 21. Interstate 880 will have 45. Interstate 980 will

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The Flock Safety cameras allow law enforcement agencies to search the data they capture for crime-linked vehicles and receive real-time alerts about them, Coffee said. The company allows data retention up to 60 days, but CHP's contract will only allow it to collect, store and share data from the cameras for up to 28 days.

In response to privacy concerns, CHP said it will put cameras in public spaces only to "solve crimes such as freeway shootings, carjackings, and auto theft."

The footage will not be viewable by third parties except for California law enforcement agencies and officials, Coffee said. That includes the investigating

shows people's whereabouts, including when they're visiting a place of worship, participating in a protest or seeking medical treatment.

She's also concerned that California laws about not sharing automatic license plate reader data with out-of-state law enforcement won't be followed. "I think that there's also concerns about exactly who has access to this information," Hussain said.

ALPR cameras are often more concentrated in communities of color, she continued, and it could be concerning if those groups were tracked and put under more security than other groups. Hussain said she believes other alternatives could be used.

"I think the best way is probably not to use ALPR at all because of the type of information that it can reveal in terms of the location of individuals," she said. "If law enforcement agencies are in fact going to be using these cameras, then we believe that a warrant is needed in order for them to be able to search so that they can collect information."

April 1, 5:33 p.m. More than a month after he briefly deployed California Highway Patrol units to fight crime in Oakland, California Gov. Gavin Newsom isn't quite finished with confronting public safety concerns in the city.

In a [news release Friday](#), the governor's office said CHP will install a network of 480 surveillance cameras throughout Oakland streets and East Bay freeways to help law enforcement identify vehicles associated with crimes. But the plan is also drawing fire from privacy advocates.

Besides reading license plate numbers, the cameras can help law enforcement track vehicles by identifying them based on vehicle type, make and color; state; missing or covered plates; and bumper stickers, decals and roof racks. The camera system will alert law enforcement immediately when it spots a vehicle linked to a crime, the governor's office said.

Newsom's office did not reveal the specific locations of the cameras, but the release said 290 will be installed on Oakland streets and 190 will be on East Bay highways. [In a video of Newsom](#) explaining the new security cameras, posted Friday on X, formerly known as Twitter, the governor is shown standing in front of the high-crime Hegenberger corridor near Oakland International Airport.

480 new high-tech cameras are being installed along freeways and in Oakland to make the area safer.

These will help law enforcement identify vehicles linked to crimes using real-time information and alerts.

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The company has contracts with cities in many states, including California. It's also expanding in the Bay Area by securing contracts with cities like [San Jose](#), [San Mateo](#) and [Berkeley](#).

Neighborhood associations in Oakland, including Lakeshore, Crestmont and Oakmore, have also been looking into using Flock's cameras, [Oaklandside reported last week](#). The cameras would be installed on private property and would monitor cars entering a neighborhood.

But despite the spread of this technology, some community members have raised concerns about the new network of cameras, including Brian Hofer, a member of the [Oakland Privacy Advisory Commission](#). The commission is responsible for providing city leaders with privacy advice on surveillance equipment [according to its website](#)

going to be in the hands of the state, and mischief can arise from that,” Hofer told the outlet.

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The Electronic Frontier Foundation, a San Francisco-based digital rights group, has also criticized automated license plate readers, including Flock’s. The group has questioned whether the camera networks are effective and is concerned that the ALPR data could be misused to wrongly implicate someone in a crime.

The California governor’s office said the new camera network in Oakland will store data for only 28 days and the information will not be disclosed to third parties “beyond California law enforcement.”



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The surveillance cameras are the latest initiative from the governor's office this year to combat rising crime, including a raft of smash-and-grab robberies in the area where Newsom filmed his announcement. According to a citywide report, crime in 2023 across Oakland increased 17% over the previous year, with the biggest jumps in motor vehicle theft and robberies.

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In February, the governor's office deployed 120 CHP officers in Oakland and the greater East Bay to assist with cracking down on crime trends in the area, including auto burglaries, retail theft, vehicle theft and violent crime. The surge led to 71 arrests and 145 recovered stolen vehicles immediately after it concluded Feb. 9.

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April 1, 2024 | Updated April 2, 2024 5:56 p.m.



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NEWS REPORTER



Madilynne Medina is a news reporter for SFGATE. Born and raised in the Bay Area, she earned a B.S. in journalism from San Jose State, where she served as executive editor for the Spartan Daily, and has also worked at NBC Bay Area. When she's not out in the field reporting, she's likely trying a new workout or listening to The Weeknd. You can contact her at madilynne.medina@sfgate.com.

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